

American Mahjong Rules: At-a-Glance Cheat Sheet

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The Table

Players	4 (East, South, West, North). East is the dealer.
Tiles in play	152 under National Mah Jongg League rules. Boxed sets usually hold 160: two spare jokers and six blank spares.
Hand size	13 tiles. The dealer starts with 14.
Goal	14 tiles that exactly match one hand on the current year's card. Say "mah jongg" and expose.

Tile Count (152)

Group	Count	Notes
Bams, Craks, Dots (1 to 9)	108	Four of each numbered tile, three suits
Winds (N, E, W, S)	16	Four of each
Dragons	12	Red with Craks, Green with Bams, White ("Soap") with Dots; Soap also serves as zero
Flowers	8	Interchangeable with each other
Jokers	8	Two extra jokers in a 160-tile box are spares

Setup and Deal

1. Wash the tiles face down. Each player builds a wall of 19 stacks, two tiles high.
2. East rolls two dice. Count that many stacks from the right end of East's wall; break the wall there.
3. Deal four tiles at a time, three rounds each (12 tiles). East then takes the first and third tiles from the top row; the others take one each.
4. Result: East holds 14, everyone else 13. East opens by discarding a tile and naming it aloud.

The Charleston

Pass	Direction	Rule
First Charleston (mandatory)	3 right, 3 across, 3 left	The last pass may be blind: forward 1 to 3 unseen tiles you just received
Second Charleston (optional)	3 left, 3 across, 3 right	Any player may stop it before it starts
Courtesy pass	0 to 3 tiles with the player across	By agreement

Jokers are never passed. Every regular pass is exactly three tiles.

Turns and Claims

- On your turn: draw from the wall or claim the most recent discard, then discard one tile and name it.
- Claim a discard only to expose a complete pung (3), kong (4), quint (5) or sextet (6) from your card, or to declare mah jongg.
- Never claim for a single or a pair, except the tile that completes your mah jongg.
- A discard is live until the next player draws and racks. Mah jongg beats an exposure call on the same tile.

Jokers

- Stand in for any tile inside a pung, kong, quint or sextet.
- Never in a single or a pair. No jokers in Singles and Pairs hands, NEWS or the year.
- Joker swap: holding the natural tile a joker represents in any exposure, you may exchange for the joker on your turn.
- A discarded joker is dead. Winning with zero jokers doubles the hand.

Payments

Situation	Who pays what
Win on a claimed discard	Discarder pays double the card value; the other two pay face value
Self-drawn win from the wall	All three pay double
Jokerless win	Doubles again, on top of the above
Wall runs out	Wall game: no winner, no payments, redeal

Dead Hands

Wrong tile count, a false mah jongg with tiles exposed, or an exposure that fits no hand on the card. A dead player keeps tiles racked; play continues around them.

Verify every win against the current year's card before racks are broken. House traditions on payments vary; agree before the first hand.